Should Churches Use Halloween for Outreach?

By Caleb James

With Halloween drawing near, many churches are finding ways to use the holiday's popularity while navigating religious concerns about its traditions.

For many Christians, Halloween's association with supernatural themes and its historical origins raise questions about whether or not the holiday should be celebrated. Some people see Halloween as an opportunity to connect with families and introduce them to the church through events such as trunk-or-treats and fall festivals.

Bryce Woodberry, youth pastor at Simpson Creek Baptist Church in Bridgeport, West Virginia, believes that Christians can participate in Halloween-themed activities without compromising their faith, if the focus remains on community and sharing the gospel.

"I think that as Christians we have an opportunity with Halloween, like many other holidays, to engage teens and young people in the church and to use the holiday as a means to gather and evangelize," Woodberry said.

His perspective reflects a broader trend among Protestant pastors.

According to a 2022 Lifeway Research survey of 1,000 Protestant pastors, 71% encouraged church members to invite friends or neighbors to church events around Halloween. Another 58% encouraged striking up relationships with neighbors who participate in trick-or-treating.

But, that survey also said that 13% of pastors encouraged their congregations to stay away from Halloween altogether, showing differing opinions among Christians surrounding the holiday.

Woodberry said those concerns are understandable, particularly when many Halloween celebrations involve themes he believes conflict with biblical teachings.

"The pagan roots of Halloween and the ways that people celebrate can offput Christians because some of those things are inherently evil and wrong, according to God's Word," Woodberry said.

Still, he says churches can distinguish between activities that conflict with their beliefs and those that provide opportunities for ministry.

"We should use discernment and tact with how we celebrate and with what we allow ourselves to endorse or not endorse," Woodberry said.

For Woodberry, those opportunities are more than theoretical. He recalled attending a church youth group as a teenager where a costume party attracted visitors who later became regular attendees.

"Many of these people stayed and would regularly visit youth group," he said.

Woodberry also said that not every Halloween themed church event produces positive results. He criticized some productions that use dramatic depictions of death and hell, saying such presentations can push many people away from church rather than encourage involvement.

He said churches should also consider the convictions of their congregations when deciding whether to host Halloween-themed activities.